



LIFELONG

- **Funding:** \$30 million
- **Last equity round:** January 2022
- **Key investors:** Thrasio, Olive Tree Capital, Fireside Ventures, Aman Gupta, and others
- **Brands acquired:** Aurion Sports, Kraft Seeds, Gate Garden, Kriti Kalash, Skudgear, Rapidotzz, and My Newborn



EVENFLOW

- **Funding:** \$5.4 million
- **Last equity round:** December 2021
- **Key investors:** Heliad Equity Partners, MPGI Holdings, Presight Capital, 468 Capital, Whiteboard Capital, Gulf Islamic Investments
- **Brands acquired:** Pepmart Brands, Everlong Brands, Vifitkit, Frenchware, Fourth Second, etc.



POWERHOUSE91

- **Funding:** \$2.5 million
- **Last equity round:** June 2021
- **Key Investors:** CoVenture, Crossbeam Venture Partners, FJ Labs, Haresh Chawla, Ryan Anthony Gnesin, and others
- **Brands acquired:** Expertomind, Slovic Enterprise, and Azah Personal Care

Note 10club pivoted to a single-brand model in October 2023; data does not include acquisitions made by foreign registered subsidiaries/entities

Source PrivateCircle Research

has been acquired by Berlin-based Razor Group. In India, the top player Mensa and its smaller counterpart UpScalio have cut jobs, and pretty much every roll-up player has halted its brand acquisition activities. Consequently, despite being in its very infancy, questions are being raised about the viability of this business model.

AN INDIA PLAYBOOK

Mrigank Gutgutia, Partner at consultancy firm Redseer Strategy Consultants, says the Indian market offers great potential for brand building, but blindly imitating the Thrasio model won't work.

In India's \$1-trillion retail market, where discretionary spending is about \$300-400 billion, the emergence of brands with over \$1 billion in revenue, according to him, is relatively limited compared to developed economies. As the country's GDP per capita rises, more brands are expected to surface. Unlike in the US, where a significant portion of e-commerce comes from a single platform, India has diverse horizontal channels besides vertical players in quick commerce and fashion. The Thrasio model required adaptation to India's unique landscape.

"Given India's complexity and different maturity levels, that direct copy-paste model would not work here. The digital and channel complexities are much higher. We have a very large, heterogeneous customer base; each region has unique needs, and one cannot have the same playbook for each market," says Gutgutia.

Irrespective of geographies, "the major challenge" of this model, according to Utsav Agarwal, Co-founder & CEO of Indian e-commerce brand aggregator Evenflow, is managing and scaling multiple diverse brands. "All major companies at their peak were aggressively acquiring brands, thinking they would be able to run them using a centralised team. I don't think that structure works. You have to have dedicated teams or a brand manager to run each brand," he adds. Many aggregators, according to Agarwal, were caught up in the euphoria of unproven opportunity projections, "spraying and praying" their investments across various categories and sectors, without a clear strategy or expertise in any specific category.

Abhishek Ganguly, the former MD of Puma India and Southeast Asia, considers 'focus' to be the guiding principle as he navigates his entrepreneurial journey at Agilitas Sports, a platform for sportswear and athleisure. Agilitas aims to acquire and license brands exclusively within the sports category. In a unique move, the company started its journey by acquiring Mochiko, a sports footwear manufacturer catering to brands like Adidas, New Balance, and Reebok. The company aims to create a portfolio of just three-four brands over the next five years through a mix of acquisitions and licensing. Ganguly has opted for a comprehensive approach in his niche